Future of AI in audio

It's all about removing friction from listening experiences, says **Harman's Armin P**

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AI is changing how companies build products and manage their operations. At Harman International, this approach extends to audio product development, where AI could help simplify engineering, bring advanced features to affordable devices, and make listening more personal.

In an interaction with Digit at JBL's 80th anniversary event in Seoul, South Korea, Armin Prommersberger, CTO of Harman International, spoke about how the company is adopting AI, its potential across consumer, professional, and automotive audio, and how it could make audio seamless.



Armin Prommersberger
CTO of Harman International

Q You have argued that companies need to rethink their systems and processes to adopt AI effectively. What does this mean in practice at Harman?

A Armin Prommersberger: At Harman, we have a company-wide initiative focused on accelerating AI adoption. The first step is to understand how people work before deciding where AI can help.

A workflow involves more than the steps recorded in a company's software. Employees may have to call someone for information, export data, perform a manual task and then import the data again. We map these steps to understand the complete process and why it exists. Only then do we redesign it with the people involved and identify where AI can help.

Software development is a good example. Earlier, a team might have 20 programmers, a team leader, a project manager and a scrum master working together to solve a problem. But the team could face fragmented code repositories, missing documentation and a lack of shared context.

AI can help us build software much faster, but the quality of the outcome depends on having the right information, a well-organised codebase and a source of truth. We are therefore rethinking team structures and bringing together people with different skills, including system architects, product managers and engineers who can use AI effectively.

The change is significant. Teams can now make multiple code commits and submit several pull requests within an hour. But this pace can also be mentally draining. We have introduced mandatory coffee breaks every 90 minutes to help people step away from their screens.

The biggest challenge is not necessarily the technology itself. It is the human side of change. You need to understand existing workflows, what technology makes possible and what people are ultimately trying to achieve. Simply adding AI everywhere will not make a process better.

Q How is AI changing the way Harman develops products and improves the listening experience?

A Armin Prommersberger: AI has two broad applications: enterprise AI, which helps us work efficiently, and product AI, which helps us develop better products and experiences.

On the enterprise side, AI allows us to test features faster, explore new designs and make changes more consistently. It helps us move through development cycles more quickly.

On the product side, there are visible AI features and others that work in the background. A clear example is the JBL BandBox range, which uses AI-powered technology to separate musical elements. As a drummer, I find this useful because I can play along with my favourite songs while removing the drum track.

I am also interested in AI that works without requiring users to interact with it directly. Audio systems use information from microphones, speakers, sensors and the content being played to understand the situation and adjust the experience.

Imagine that you are watching a film on a Saturday night. An intelligent system could recognise your preferences, prepare the surround sound system with suitable Dolby Atmos settings, switch the TV to its movie mode and dim the lights. You would only need to ask it to play the film.

We could bring the knowledge of our audio engineers into a virtual system that lives in your headphones or speakers. Rather than sending an engineer to every customer's home to adjust the sound, the system could continuously optimise audio settings for the best possible experience.

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